chromosomal data consistently suggest a largely South Asian origin for Indian caste communities'. [30] Genetic studies suggest that Indian castes are profoundly influenced by 'founder events'. Roughly speaking, this means that castes are created by an 'event' when a group separates out and turns itself into an endogamous 'tribe'. Over time this process leads to a heterogeneous milieu of groups and sub-groups, sometimes combining and sometimes splitting off. The result is that, despite centuries of mixing, we do not have a unified population but a complex network of clans. This is a good description of the messy 'Jati'-based social system that exists to this day

Genetics also tells us that there is no real difference between groups that we differentiate today as 'castes' and 'tribes'. As India's leading geneticist, Dr. Lalji Singh puts it, 'It is impossible to distinguish castes and tribes from the data. This supports the view that castes grew directly out of tribe-like organizations during the formation of Indian society. The one exception to the finding, that all Indian groups are mixed, is the indigenous people of the Andaman islands …' [31]

In order to appreciate the messiness of the Jati system of castes, note the distribution of the R1a1 genetic haplogroup, the genes many Indians share with Eastern Europeans. [32] Their distribution in India across region and caste is telling. It is present in high concentration among high-caste Brahmins of Bengal and Konkan as well as in Punjabi Khatris, but it also shows up in tribes such as the Chenchus of Andhra Pradesh. In other words, a Chenchu tribesman is closely related to an upper-caste Bengali 'bhadralok' and a blond Lithuanian. You never know where you will bump into relatives. A paper published in the *Journal of Human Genetics* in January 2009, argues that the R1a1 lineage probably originated in India. The study argues for 'the autochthonous origin of R1a1 lineage in India and a tribal link to Indian Brahmins'. [33] Thus, we may well be dealing with a particularly successful Neolithic clan that branched out in different directions and whose descendants experienced very different fates.